
3.6 Unit 3, Option D: The Challenge of Fascism

Unit 3, Option D: Topic D1 From Kaiser to Führer: Germany, 1900-45 is a prohibited combination with Unit 1, Option F: The Expansion and Challenge of Nationalism. This is because Unit 1, Topic F7: *From Second Reich to Third Reich: Germany, 1918-45* overlaps in content with Unit 3, Topic D1. However, centres wishing to offer Unit 3, Topic D1, may enter students for Unit 1, Option E.

There is no prohibited combination between Unit 1 Option F and Unit 3: Option D, Topic D2: *Britain and the Challenge of Fascism: Saving Europe at a Cost? c1925-60*.

Focus

This option concentrates on the nature of, and policies associated with, imperial, democratic and authoritarian regimes in Germany in the first half of the 20th century and how these regimes influenced social change. It also concentrates on how British foreign policy attempted to deal with the perceived threat of Nazi Germany, how Britain survived and triumphed in the Second World War and how the experience of war affected social change both during wartime and as the nation grappled with post-war reconstruction.

Students are required to study a range of factors associated with social and political change. They also address, and are invited to pass reasoned judgement upon issues which have provoked disagreement and controversy among historians. A key element of study in Option D1 relates to the evaluation of interpretations relating to responsibility for the outbreak of the First World War and the popularity and efficiency of the Nazi regime in Germany. A key element of study in Option D2 relates to the effectiveness of pre-Second World War diplomacy and the impact of world war in the case of Britain.

Clarification of content for each topic can be found in *Appendix 1*.

Students entered for Option D are required to study ONE topic: D1 or D2.

D1 From Kaiser to Führer: Germany, 1900-45

- The Second Reich — society and government in Germany, c1900-19: economic expansion; political and social tensions; the impact of the First World War.
- The democratic experiment, 1919-29: crises and survival, 1919-24; Stresemann and recovery; the 'Golden Years' of the Weimar Republic; Weimar culture.
- The rise of the Nazis: origins to 1928; impact of the slump in town and country, 1928-33; growing support; coming to power.
- Life in wartime Germany, 1939-45: opposition and conformity; persecution of the Jews and the development of the idea of the 'Final Solution'; the efficiency of the war economy.

Associated controversies

- a) To what extent was Germany responsible for the outbreak of the First World War?
- b) How popular and efficient was the Nazi regime in the years 1933-39?

D2 Britain and the Challenge of Fascism: Saving Europe at a Cost? c1925-60

- British foreign policy 1925-37: dealing with dictators by peaceful means; relations with Mussolini, 1925-37; relations with Hitler and Germany, 1933-37; the role of public opinion in influencing policy.
- Defeat and survival, 1939-41: military setbacks; the Battle of Britain (1940); war in north Africa and the Atlantic.
- Victory and the Grand Alliance 1942-45: the Mediterranean, 1942-44; the Battle of the Atlantic; the bomber offensive; D-Day and the liberation of Europe.
- The Home Front: morale, war production, social change 1939-45.

Associated controversies

- a) Was British foreign policy in the years 1937-39 a triumph or a disaster for Britain?
- b) Was the social and economic impact of the war on Britain positive or negative in the years 1945-60?